

Blake Sawyer
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EDUCATION

- Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University, Blacksburg, VA*
Ph.D. in Human-Computer Interaction **2011-Present**
Dissertation Topic: Using physical social interactions to organize personal media/information to support re-finding
- Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University, Blacksburg, VA*
M.S. in Human-Computer Interaction **2011**
Thesis Topic: Using physical social interactions to organize personal media/information to support re-finding
- Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University, Blacksburg, VA*
B.A. Computer Science **2007**
Areas of Concentration: User Interface Design, Human-Computer Interaction
Minor: Mathematics
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RECENT PROJECTS

- Social Orbits: Social Context of Information Access** **2008-Present**
 - Examines the role that our physical social interactions play in how users access and re-find their media information
 - Developing re-finding tool that tags and organizes information based on user's social world/interactions
 - Conducting ethnographic/quantitative user studies
- The Splash App** **2013-Present**
 - AppStore iOS app that allows people to share, view and vote on pictures happening around them right now
 - Splashes that are popular last longer and get bigger on the map, splashes that are not get smaller and eventually disappear
- Musical MAKer Camp** **2012-Present**
 - Lead graduate assistant in the creation, design and execution of musical instrument maker summer camp
 - Middle schoolers use cardboard and 3D printing to create custom musical instruments with electronic sensors and GUI music programming
- VTTI Distracted Driver Game and Connected Vehicle Derby** **2013-2014**
 - Designed and developed distracted driving simulator game to engage early drivers with the dangers of texting while driving
 - Designed and built system for a cardboard connected vehicle derby where middle-schoolers' cardboard cars were sensed providing real-time lap times and collision detection
- GreenStar: Smart-grid Technology Starts in the Home** **2011-2012**
 - Explored business startup that enables homeowners and dorm residents to monitor and control their energy usage
 - Prototyped and built smart, energy reporting power outlets and developed front end website
 - Finalists in local, regional and collegiate entrepreneurship competition

EXPERIENCE

Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University, Blacksburg, VA

Graduate Research Assistant

2008-Present

- Developing social re-finding system and conducting quantitative/ethnographic user studies.
- Manage rapid prototyping lab for physical computing research.

National University of Singapore

Graduate Research Assistant

2008-2011

Remote grant collaboration researching social and multimedia interactions in ubiquitous computing environments

Virginia Polytechnic Institute and State University, Blacksburg, VA

IT Manager

2007-2008

Managed a team of students to support Virginia Tech engineering students computing needs

Strengthening Our System, Inc., Floyd, VA

Care Giver

2007

Provided support for teen with Asperger's Syndrome and young adult with cerebral palsy

Virginia Tech Information Technology Acquisition, Blacksburg, VA

Programmer

2005-2006

Maintained and developed software for student software distribution servers

MITRE Corporation, Suffolk, VA

Intern

2004

Java network programming and software design

PUBLICATIONS

- Sawyer et al. "Form, Function and Performances in a Musical Instrument MAKERs Camp." Proceeding of the 44th ACM Technical Symposium on Computer Science Education (SIGCSE) March 2013, Denver, CO.
- Sawyer et al. "Using Physical-Social Interactions to Support Information Re-finding." ACM CHI May 2012 in Austin, TX.
- Sawyer et al. "Information Re-finding Through Physical-Social Contexts." Workshop on Personal Information Management February 2012 in CSCW '12 Seattle, WA.

TALKS

- Sawyer, Blake. "GreenStar: Smart-grid technology starts in the home." Finalist in ACC Clean Energy 100K Challenge, Department of Energy, College Park, MD, April 2012.
- Sawyer, Blake and Ressler, Stephen. "GreenStar." Finalist in Virginia Tech Knowledge Works E-Competition, Blacksburg, VA, April 2012.
- Sawyer, Blake and Ressler, Stephen. "Affordable Energy Management for the Home." Startup Madness, Raleigh, NC, March 2012.
- Sawyer, Blake. "SocialOrb: Personal Information Meets Our Social World." Center for Human Computer Interaction Seminar Series at Virginia Tech, February 2011.
- Sawyer, Blake. "The Need for Light-weight Location Awareness and Qualitative Methods." National University of Singapore, December 2009.

SKILLS

Experienced system designer, programmer and program language learner

- Mac OS X, Windows, Android, iOS, XCode, .NET, Eclipse, Apache, AWS EC2, Node.js
- Objective-C, C/C++, Java, PHP, Core Data, SQL and Non-SQL databases, HTML/CSS, JavaScript, jQuery, Python, Ruby on Rails

Proficient in quantitative, qualitative and ethnographic methods

- User study and experiment design with statistical analysis
- Interviewing, observations, grounded theory method, open-coding
- NSF ICorp graduate in conducting real customer discovery, problem and solution validation

Capable of designing and prototyping hardware devices

- Circuit and CAD design
- Printing circuit boards on computer controlled mill
- Surface mounting using reflow

Airplane Single Engine Land Private Pilot

- Completed July 2014 in C-172M
- 60+ hours PIC